

Literary Remix Project Worksheet

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Title of Source Material: Tragic Love and Societal Norms: Tale of Sohni Mahiwal

Select Source Material:

(2 Marks)

What story have you chosen for your remix project?

Sohni Mahiwal

Why did you choose this particular story?

This story includes many social and cultural dynamics that are relevant to this day. The story is short, yet packs a multitude of commentaries on love, affection, culture, and conservatism while remaining simple and universal.

Analyze and Deconstruct:

(3+3+3=9 Marks)

Identify key themes, characters, plot points, and stylistic elements of the source material.

The main theme is a tragic love that tries to survive despite all the attempts against it. The main characters are Sohni and Mahiwal, with Sohni's family playing a side role. Sohni and Mahiwal's love is the main plot point, alongside barriers that are placed between them by other people. It is a very Punjabi story at heart, with potters and the river Chenab being a major part of the story.

What are the core elements of the story that you believe are essential to retain in your remix?

The forbidden love between two individuals aspect of the story is essential to retain for the remix. Alongside the love aspect, a clear physical barrier between the two that separates them physically at a moment in time is also essential to retain. The tragic end of the original story also is to be retained.

What are the elements of the story that you feel could be expanded, altered, or removed to better suit your remix concept?

One of the most important aspects that are to be altered is the setting and time in which the story is. From pre-modern Punjab to Bangladesh in 1971, the remix's setting changed dramatically. Removing Sohni's husband from the story also gives the story a more somber and naturally fatalistic feeling. The method of Sohni's death also changes with the setting since in the original story she dies by drowning in the Chenab River.

Brainstorm Remix Ideas:

(3+3+3=9 Marks)

Generate at least three potential remix ideas for your project.

1. Sohni, from East Pakistan, falls in love with Mahiwal, who's from West Pakistan during the backdrop of the chaos of 1971.
2. Sohni has to migrate to a new country, Pakistan, but Mahiwal cannot leave his family behind and go with his lover. They get caught up in the hostilities of the partition.
3. Sohni is a spy from East Pakistan, in the backdrop of 1971, who ends up entangling with a West Pakistani soldier who's also on an intelligence mission. This complicates both of their missions.

Consider different perspectives, genres, settings, and narrative styles for each idea.

The first idea could be written from the perspective of Mahiwal, who is standing at the end of a tunnel that runs under the border, waiting for Sohni to arrive, but she never does. This changes the setting but also the genre since it becomes more of a historical drama than just a Shakespearean tragedy. The second can be written with the third-person perspective of a partition historian and detailing incidents from the event.

How do these remix ideas transform or reinterpret the original story?

The remix ideas transform the story by primarily changing the setting and the time period in which the story takes place. This also completely transforms the barrier that is placed between the love of the two individuals as in the original story it is the forced marriage being the emotional barrier while the river is the physical barrier, whereas in the remix, the emotional barrier is that of having two different identities/motives and the physical barrier is the border between two different states.

Create Remix Work: (350-500 words)

(20 Marks)

Begin drafting new scenes, dialogue, or narratives for your remix. Write the complete remix/story.

Every twitch of a branch, every sound from an owl, sounded like her making her way through that tunnel. He stood right next to its entrance. It stretched from within the Indian border all the way to the nearest Pakistani check post. She had promised she would make it across the border today, but he had been restless for an entire week.

Before the war of 1971 had begun, Sohni, an East Pakistani woman, and Mahiwal, a soldier from West Pakistan found themselves falling deep into a forbidden love affair. Their love strengthened in secret, both ready to lay their lives for each other, even though they knew that their families and the war in the world around them would never approve. As the war started, the hostilities became worse and they became closer and stronger.

As the war was getting serious, Mahiwal was stationed on the front lines, fighting the "enemy". Leaving Sohni behind, who was desperate to reunite with her love.

Meanwhile, Mahiwal, torn between his duty as a soldier and his love for Sohni, started questioning reality. He began to ask for answers for all the violence that was created without any motive. Who was his true enemy?

It was hatred. And he was a man of love.

Sohni fled from what she thought was her home, to Mahiwal, for her home was where he was. Mahiwal's letters to his lover pleaded for her to make her way through India and reach a tunnel that could easily get her across the border, and reunite the lovers once and forever.

After months of bearing the grueling, torturous nature of the distance between two lovers, Mahiwal was confident after he received a letter from Sohni that she would give it her all to make it across that tunnel, and that if she didn't make it, she was probably dead.

And now, he stood, waiting. His legs were weak, his heart heavy with every passing second that he didn't see her approaching him. On the other side of the tunnel, Sohni lay dead near the entrance to the tunnel, a bullet to the back by an Indian Border Patrol Guard.

But he waited. Waited a little more. A little more. And then the wait broke with a tear passing down his cheek. It was gone, just as she was.

Mahiwal grew to never forget his lover. He felt privileged to have been the man that she loved. It was his greatest honor. Their love became a symbol of the fact that whatever destruction war and hate bring forth, the human soul will always yearn to die in the name of love.